LUKMAAN IAS

A LEADING INSTITUTE FOR IAS EXAMINATION

ISSUE - 1

Revised & Expanded Edition

UPSC CSE | PERSONALITY TEST (INTERVIEW)

Current Issues for the Interview

Probable Questions with View-Based Answers

SEPTEMBER 2026

National Affairs | Society & Security | Economic Affairs | Ecology | International Relations | Science & Tech

26 board questions • Follow-up chains • DAF hooks • Month at a glance • Practice rubric

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How to Use This Issue

This issue carries **26 probable board questions** on the issue-based developments of **September 2026** across six areas. Each answer can be spoken in 60–90 seconds. Event-only items such as awards, sports and important days are left out; every question here asks for your opinion.

Facts are **as on 30 September 2026**. A few October developments that change the picture (the RBI rate hike, the India–New Zealand FTA coming into force) are marked **UPDATE (OCT)**.

EVERY ANSWER IN THIS ISSUE HAS SEVEN PARTS	
My View	Your position in one sentence. Say it first.
Reasoning	Two reasons, one hard fact. Not five numbers.
Counterpoint I Accept	The strongest argument against you, conceded honestly.
Way Forward	What you would do, ideally as an administrator.
Must-Know	Two or three facts (Article, Act, committee, number) that boards like to check.
Follow-up Chain	How a board member is likely to press you, probe by probe, with crisp replies.
DAF Hooks	How the topic may be linked to your optional, graduation or home state.

ANSWER SPINE: View → Two reasons + one fact → Counterpoint I accept → Way forward (60–90 seconds)

September 2026 at a Glance

Read this page in the waiting room. Each line is a hook the board can use to open a conversation.

26 Aug	Rasuwa flash flood from Tibet hits Nepal's hydropower corridor	ECOLOGY
31 Aug	Q1 FY27 GDP growth: 7.8%	ECONOMY
31 Aug–1 Sep	SCO Summit, Bishkek	IR
1–30 Sep	Census houselisting in Manipur amid NRC demands	SOCIETY
4 Sep	ISRO launches GSLV-F17/EOS-05	S&T
11 Sep	Modi–Putin bilateral talks in New Delhi	IR
12–13 Sep	18th BRICS Summit; New Delhi Declaration; Modi–Xi talks	IR
16 Sep	New Zealand Parliament passes India–NZ FTA	ECONOMY
17–19 Sep	SEMICON India; $13.5 bn Semicon 2.0	S&T
22 Sep	UNGA high-level General Debate opens	IR
26 Sep	ECI orders ECINET review; eases SIR hearings	NATIONAL
28 Sep	August IIP growth: 8.0%	ECONOMY
30 Sep	Monsoon ends at 87% of LPA; Census houselisting window closes	ECOLOGY
7 Oct	UPDATE: RBI raises repo rate to 5.50%	ECONOMY
20 Oct	UPDATE: India–NZ FTA comes into force	ECONOMY

Refresh Before Your Interview

These figures move fast. Values are as on 30 September 2026 (October updates noted). Write the latest value in the last column on the eve of your interview.

Indicator	As on this issue	Latest (fill in)
CPI inflation	4.82% (August)	
RBI repo rate	5.25% → 5.50% (7 Oct)	
Indian crude basket	≈ $100.75/bbl (Sept avg)	
Strait of Hormuz	Effectively closed since Feb	
India–US trade deal	Not finalised; tariff 18%	
El Niño status	Very strong (Sept)	
Gaganyaan G1 (uncrewed)	Targeted within 2026	
Census Phase 2 / caste questions	To be notified	
Women's reservation timeline	Linked to delimitation	
CEC removal demand / protests	Ongoing (Oct)	

SECTION 01

National Affairs

GS-II: Polity & Governance

CONTEXT CAPSULE The Gen Z-led "Cockroach Janta Party" protests over paper leaks forced the Education Minister's resignation on 25 July and continued through September–October. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, upheld by the Supreme Court on 27 May, ran in phases; on 26 September the Election Commission ordered a review of its ECINET platform and eased the hearing process.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Public Administration optional	*"Is the paper-leak crisis a failure of Weberian bureaucracy or of outsourcing under New Public Management?"*	Both: outsourcing without accountability (NPM's weak spot) plus rigid, opaque processes. Argue for New Public Service: transparency and citizen voice.
Law / Political Science graduate	*"Is the CEC appointment law of 2023 consistent with the Anoop Baranwal judgment?"*	Parliament can legislate (the judgment itself said so till a law is made); the question is whether executive majority on the panel meets the spirit of independence.
Engineering / Computer Science	*"Can technology make exams leak-proof?"*	It can shrink the window, not remove human risk: encryption, randomised sets, audit logs, plus vendor accountability.
Home state Jharkhand / Bihar / UP	*"Why do recruitment scandals recur in your state?"*	Huge applicant-to-post ratios, contractual vendors, delayed calendars. Cite the JPSC protests and suggest a fixed recruitment calendar.

Q1 Youth protests over paper leaks have spread from Jantar Mantar to Jharkhand. Are these a threat to governance or a healthy democratic signal?

MY VIEW: A democratic signal, and a governance warning that the state should treat as feedback, not as a law-and-order problem.

The grievance is real. In one Jharkhand recruitment exercise, about 6.4 lakh applicants competed for 2,025 posts. When a paper leaks, years of a young person's life are erased. Peaceful assembly is a right under Article 19, and a minister's resignation shows the system can respond.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT If dialogue fails, frustration can turn violent, as Nepal and Bangladesh showed recently, and some groups may exploit genuine anger for political ends.

WAY FORWARD A standing dialogue mechanism with student bodies, time-bound results, and visible convictions under the 2024 anti-unfair-means law. Trust returns when punishment is certain, not when protests stop.

MUST-KNOW Art. 19(1)(b): right to assemble peaceably and without arms; Art. 19(3) permits reasonable restrictions for public order. Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024: 3–5 years' jail for individuals; 5–10 years and fine of at least ₹1 crore for organised crime. Education Minister resigned on 25 July 2026.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Would you, as a District Magistrate, permit such a protest?"* → Yes, with conditions on venue and time. My job is to protect the right to protest and public order together.
P2	*"What if it turns violent?"* → Graded response: dialogue with organisers, then lawful dispersal with minimum force, video-recorded. Prosecute the violent, not the movement.
P3	*"Aren't these protests politically motivated?"* → Some may be, but the grievance is verifiable. Fix the grievance and the politics loses its fuel.

Q2 If you were given charge of a recruitment commission, what three reforms would you make to stop paper leaks?

MY VIEW: Leaks are a supply-chain failure, so fix the chain, not just punish the thief.

1. **Shrink the exposure window.** Encrypted digital question papers released minutes before the exam, with multiple sets generated randomly.
2. **Professionalise the vendor ecosystem.** Most leaks occur at printing, transport or outsourced test centres. Blacklist, audit and insure every vendor.
3. **Fix the calendar.** A published annual recruitment calendar with fixed result dates. Uncertainty makes aspirants desperate and middlemen profitable.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Going fully online is not a silver bullet. Remote-access cheating at private centres is now the new leak, and rural candidates may face access gaps.

WAY FORWARD Government-owned test centres in every district over five years, with supervision that moves with the technology.

MUST-KNOW The K. Radhakrishnan committee (2024) recommended reforms to the NTA, including a shift towards computer-based testing and tighter centre control. The 2024 Act also makes service providers liable and can bar them from conducting exams for four years.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Your reforms need money. Where will it come from?"* → Exam fees already fund commissions; one cancelled exam costs more than the reforms. It is a saving, not a cost.
P2	*"UPSC has rarely had leaks. Why?"* → Fewer, centralised exams, its own secure processes and a fixed calendar. State commissions should copy the model.
P3	*"Should exams be conducted by private agencies at all?"* → Only under strict contracts with audits and penalties; the core, paper setting and custody, must stay public.

Q3 The SIR has been called both an exercise in electoral purity and a route to mass disenfranchisement. Where do you stand?

MY VIEW: The goal is legitimate; the burden of proof is where it can go wrong.

Clean rolls are a constitutional need. Duplicate, dead and shifted voters weaken free and fair elections, and the Supreme Court upheld the exercise. The Court also clarified that the Election Commission does not decide citizenship and that Aadhaar proves identity.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT The poor migrant or flood-displaced woman may be unable to produce old documents in time. Excluding one genuine voter is a bigger wrong than retaining one ineligible name a few months longer.

WAY FORWARD House visits before deletion, a reasoned order for every removal, free appeal, and booth-wise publication of deletion data. The 26 September ECINET review is welcome: if software flags a voter, a human officer must decide, and the code must be auditable.

MUST-KNOW Art. 324: superintendence of elections; Art. 326: adult suffrage. Sec. 21(3), Representation of the People Act, 1950: power to order a special revision. ADR v. ECI, 27 May 2026: SIR upheld; citizenship not decided by the ECI.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Who should prove eligibility: the voter or the state?"*
→ For an existing voter, the state should show cause before deletion; the presumption should favour inclusion.

P2 *"Then how do you remove illegal names?"*
→ Through due process: notice, hearing, reasoned order. Slower, but it survives judicial and public scrutiny.

P3 *"Should algorithms flag voters at all?"*
→ Yes, as a first filter. But no one should lose a vote because of code that no one can audit.

Q4 Some protesters and opposition parties have demanded the Chief Election Commissioner's resignation. How do you see the credibility of the Election Commission today?

MY VIEW: The Commission is a strong institution, but its credibility depends on being seen as neutral, not only being neutral.

India's elections are accepted across parties, which is the ultimate test. But perception matters. The 2023 law placing a Union minister, not the Chief Justice, on the selection panel has made every controversial decision look political.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Constant attacks on the Commission by losing parties can themselves erode trust in a body that has a strong record; not every criticism is evidence of bias.

WAY FORWARD A broader selection panel, regular press interaction explaining big decisions like SIR, and open data so that citizens can verify claims rather than rely on allegations. I would not comment on any individual.

MUST-KNOW Art. 324(5): CEC removable only like a Supreme Court judge. Anoop Baranwal v. UoI (2023): PM, LoP and CJI panel until Parliament legislates. CEC and Other ECs Act, 2023: panel of PM, LoP and a Union Cabinet minister.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"So you think the government has compromised the EC?"*
→ No, sir. I am saying institutional design should remove even the room for doubt. That protects the Commission itself.

P2 *"Should the CJI be on the panel?"*
→ A neutral third member, whether CJI or another, would strengthen perception; the principle matters more than the person.

P3 *"Is protest against a constitutional authority legitimate?"*
→ Peaceful criticism is; personal attacks and attempts to delegitimise elections are not.

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SECTION 02

Society & Internal Security

GS-I: Society | GS-II: Social Justice | GS-III: Internal Security

CONTEXT CAPSULE The first phase of the digital, caste-enumerating Census 2027 (houselisting) closed its national window on 30 September; Manipur ran its round from 1–30 September amid NRC demands. Women's reservation remains tied to delimitation after the 131st Amendment Bill failed in April, with the debate reviving in August. Digital-arrest frauds keep rising, while Left Wing Extremism has shrunk to a handful of districts after the March 2026 deadline.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Sociology / Anthropology optional	*"Will caste enumeration strengthen or weaken caste identity?"*	Data does not create identity; it reveals inequality. Cite Srinivas on dominant caste and the 1931 baseline problem.
Woman candidate / gender studies	*"Why should women's quota wait for delimitation?"*	It should not have to; argue for delinking with a rotation formula on existing seats.
Home state Chhattisgarh / Odisha / Jharkhand	*"Is Naxalism over in your state?"*	Militarily close to it; politically it ends only when Forest Rights and PESA deliver.
Tamil Nadu / Kerala / South	*"Will delimitation punish your state for controlling population?"*	Propose weighting or a freeze extension, and a stronger Rajya Sabha role for federal balance.

Q5 Women's reservation is law, but tied to delimitation. Should it be delinked and implemented in 2029 on existing seats?

MY VIEW: Yes. Representation of half the population should not wait for a contested redrawing of the map.

The 2023 amendment promised one-third of seats but linked it to the next Census and delimitation. The 131st Amendment Bill, which proposed expanding the Lok Sabha from 543 to 850 seats, failed in April 2026. Every delay pushes the promise further away.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Implementing on existing seats means reserving a third of sitting members' constituencies by rotation, which is politically hard; expansion makes it easier because no sitting MP loses out.

WAY FORWARD Reserve one-third of current seats by rotation from 2029, and settle delimitation separately with a federal consensus. Panchayats have shown since 1993 that women's reservation works.

MUST-KNOW 106th Amendment Act, 2023 (Nari Shakti Vandan): Arts. 330A, 332A, 334A. 131st Amendment Bill failed in the Lok Sabha on 17 April 2026. 73rd/74th Amendments (1992): one-third reservation for women in local bodies.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Won't rotation weaken MPs' bond with constituencies?"*
→ Partly, but panchayats manage it, and parties can field the same leaders elsewhere.

P2 *"Should there be a quota within the quota for OBC women?"*
→ It is a fair demand to examine after caste data from the Census; I would not make it a reason to delay.

P3 *"Does reservation help only elite women?"*
→ Initially perhaps; over two decades, panchayat data shows new women leaders emerging from below.

Q6 Census 2027 will count caste for the first time since 1931. Is that a step forward or a risk to social harmony?

MY VIEW: A step forward. You cannot fix what you do not measure, and social justice without data is guesswork.

Reservation, welfare and the creamy layer all rely on caste-based estimates nearly a century old. The 2011 SECC caste data was never fully released because of errors. A careful, digital count can finally anchor policy in evidence.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Caste data can be used to harden identities and feed competitive politics, and misclassification can create new disputes, as the SECC showed.

WAY FORWARD A standard, pre-coded caste list to avoid lakhs of variants, independent expert review before release, and use of the data for targeting welfare rather than only for quota politics.

MUST-KNOW Last full caste census: 1931. SECC-2011 caste data unpublished. Census 2027: first digital census; houselisting window 1 April–30 September 2026; self-enumeration option; caste questions in Phase 2. Approved outlay about ₹11,718 crore.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Won't this lead to demands to remove the 50% ceiling?"*
→ Possibly. Indra Sawhney set the ceiling; any change must come through the courts and consensus, guided by data.

P2 *"Should Manipur's houselisting have been deferred over NRC demands?"*
→ No. Census counts residents, not citizens; mixing the two would compromise both.

P3 *"How will you ensure accuracy?"*
→ Pre-coded lists, trained enumerators, sample re-surveys and transparent error reporting.

Q7 Fraudsters are placing citizens under "digital arrest" and stealing crores. Is this a cyber-crime problem or a national security problem?

MY VIEW: Both. It is organised transnational crime that uses our own financial and telecom systems against us.

Losses from digital-arrest scams crossed ₹19,000 crore in 2025 by one estimate. Nearly half the operations are traced to compounds in Southeast Asia, some run with trafficked Indians, so it involves trafficking, money laundering and cross-border policing.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Treating it purely as security can lead to over-surveillance and account freezes that hurt innocent customers; most of the fix lies in banking and awareness, not policing.

WAY FORWARD A financial "kill switch" to freeze mule accounts in minutes, telecom-level blocking of spoofed numbers, cooperation with Myanmar, Cambodia and Laos, and a simple public message: police never arrest anyone on a video call.

MUST-KNOW There is no legal concept of "digital arrest" in Indian law; arrest procedures are under the BNSS, 2023. I4C (MHA) runs the 1930 helpline and cybercrime.gov.in. I4C estimates 45–46% of such operations originate in Southeast Asia.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Who should bear the loss: bank or customer?"*
→ If the bank failed basic checks on a mule account, it should share the loss; that incentive will improve monitoring.

P2 *"As SP, what would you do in week one?"*
→ A district cyber cell with bank nodal officers, a 1930 response target, and awareness through schools and post offices.

P3 *"Isn't the real problem low digital literacy?"*
→ Partly, but even educated professionals fall victim. Design the system so one mistake is not ruinous.

Q8 The government set March 2026 as the deadline to end Naxalism. Is the problem over?

MY VIEW: The armed insurgency is nearly over; the conditions that created it are not.

Affected districts fell from about 200 in 2000 to just 7 by early 2026. Roads, mobile towers, surrenders and coordinated operations have broken the movement's military capacity. That is a genuine security achievement.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Declaring victory early is risky. Land alienation, mining displacement and weak Forest Rights Act implementation can revive grievances, and the movement has regrouped before.

WAY FORWARD A phased drawdown of forces, with the vacated space filled by schools, health centres, PESA and FRA implementation, and local recruitment into police and administration.

MUST-KNOW About 200 LWE-affected districts (2000) → 7 (early 2026); 31 "legacy thrust" districts to keep support. SAMADHAN strategy (2017) for LWE. PESA, 1996 and the Forest Rights Act, 2006 are the key governance tools.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Was the deadline-based approach right?"*
→ Deadlines focus effort, but the real metric is no relapse in five years, not a date.

P2	*"What about human rights concerns in operations?"* → Credibility needs prompt inquiries into every civilian death; legitimacy is a force multiplier.
P3	*"As Collector of a former LWE district, your first priority?"* → Trust: Gram Sabha meetings, FRA title distribution and functioning schools within months.

SECTION 03

Economic Affairs

GS-III: Indian Economy

CONTEXT CAPSULE Q1 FY27 GDP grew 7.8% (released 31 August), yet CPI inflation hit 4.82% in August, the third month above the 4% target. India's crude basket averaged about $100.75 a barrel in September with Hormuz effectively shut since the Iran war began in February. The monsoon ended at 87% of LPA. UPDATE (OCT): the RBI raised the repo rate by 25 bps to 5.50% on 7 October.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Economics graduate / optional	*"Supply shock: should a central bank look through it?"*	Usually yes, unless expectations de-anchor and the currency is under pressure, which is the case now.
Agriculture / rural background	*"How did the weak monsoon affect your district?"*	Prepare one local fact: sowing area, reservoir level or crop price.
Engineering / management	*"Is India's FTA push good for manufacturing?"*	Yes, if paired with rules of origin and productivity reforms.
Public Administration optional	*"Is the RBI's independence an example of an autonomous agency?"*	Link to agencification and the MPC as a rule-based institution.

Q9 India grew 7.8% last quarter, but inflation is rising and the rupee is weak. Is the Indian economy resilient or heading towards stagflation?

MY VIEW: Resilient at the core, vulnerable at the edges. It is not stagflation, but it is an imported-inflation shock.

Growth is broad-based and capex-led, with August industrial output up 8%. Stagflation means stagnant growth with high inflation; we have strong growth with moderate inflation. The vulnerability is external: oil at $100 widens the current account deficit, weakens the rupee and raises fertiliser and transport costs.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Headline GDP can hide stress: households feel prices, informal workers feel the slowdown first, and a weak monsoon may hit rural demand in the second half.

WAY FORWARD Let the RBI anchor expectations, keep fiscal discipline, and target relief to the poor rather than blanket fuel subsidies. The test of resilience is the next two quarters.

MUST-KNOW Q1 FY27 real GDP: 7.8% (MoSPI, 31 August 2026). CPI inflation, August 2026: 4.82%; target 4% ± 2%. Fiscal deficit April–August: ₹7.10 lakh crore (41.9% of BE).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Then why do people feel poorer?"* → Because prices are felt daily and GDP is not. Real wages, not GDP, decide how people feel.
P2	*"Should the government cut fuel taxes?"* → Partly and temporarily, as long as the fiscal deficit stays on track; direct support to the poor is better targeted.
P3	*"Is the GDP data credible?"* → The methodology is debated, but high-frequency indicators like IIP, GST and credit growth broadly confirm the trend.

Q10 The RBI has raised rates even though growth is strong and the shock is from oil supply. Was it the right call?

MY VIEW: Yes, on balance. A rate hike cannot produce oil, but it can stop an oil shock from becoming a wage-and-price spiral.

Inflation has stayed above target for three months and is spreading beyond food and fuel. The rupee is near record lows and foreign investors are exiting. Strong growth gives the RBI room to act. A 25 bps move with a unanimous vote is calibrated, not aggressive.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Supply shocks are usually "looked through"; higher rates hurt MSMEs and housing, and if Hormuz reopens, the hike may prove unnecessary.

WAY FORWARD Data-dependent guidance, liquidity support for MSMEs, and coordination with the government on supply-side steps like buffer-stock release.

MUST-KNOW UPDATE (OCT): repo raised to 5.50% on 7 October 2026, first hike in over three years. MPC: 6 members; flexible inflation targeting under Sec. 45ZA, RBI Act (2016).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Then why not hike by 50 bps?"* → Because the shock may reverse if Hormuz reopens. A measured step keeps the option to pause.
P2	*"Doesn't a hike defeat the government's capex push?"* → Short-term, marginally. Unchecked inflation would raise borrowing costs far more.
P3	*"Should the RBI defend the rupee at a level?"* → No fixed level; smooth volatility and build reserves. Defending a number burns reserves.

Q11 What lessons should India draw for energy security from the Hormuz closure?

MY VIEW: Energy security is now national security. Diversify sources, routes and fuels.

- **Sources:** India shifted quickly to Russian and spot cargoes; long-term contracts with the Americas and Africa reduce single-region dependence.
- **Storage:** strategic reserves cover only about 9–10 days; fast-track Phase-II caverns.
- **Fuels:** every unit of solar, EV, green hydrogen and ethanol is an import avoided.
- **Routes:** freedom of navigation, IMEC and Chabahar reduce chokepoint risk.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Diversification costs money: long-haul crude is pricier, and some sources come with sanctions risk and diplomatic pressure.

WAY FORWARD Treat energy like defence: a national energy-security doctrine with storage targets, supplier caps and a transition timeline.

MUST-KNOW India imports over 85% of its crude; normally about half via Hormuz. Strategic reserves: 5.33 MMT at Visakhapatnam, Mangaluru and Padur. Indian crude basket averaged about $100.75/bbl in September 2026.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should India keep buying Russian oil despite US pressure?"*
→ Decisions should follow price and national interest; we can address partners' concerns without surrendering autonomy.

P2 *"Is the energy transition realistic during a crisis?"*
→ The crisis strengthens the case: renewables are domestic energy.

P3 *"Which one step first?"*
→ Fill and expand strategic storage; it buys time in every future crisis.

Q12 The monsoon ended about 13% below normal, the weakest since 2015. How would you protect farmers and consumers?

MY VIEW: Treat it as a slow disaster, managed early, not as a crop failure discovered late.

For farmers: contingency rabi plans, seed and fodder banks, quick PMFBY settlement, and MGNREGA work opened in deficit districts. **For consumers:** buffer stocks through open-market sales. Odisha recorded a 30% surplus while others were dry, so the response must be district-specific.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Short-term relief can become permanent populism, and procurement-heavy responses keep farmers locked into water-intensive crops.

WAY FORWARD Avoid knee-jerk export bans that hurt farmers' credibility; invest in micro-irrigation, millets and pulses in rainfed areas.

MUST-KNOW Monsoon 2026: 87% of LPA (≈759 mm vs 869 mm); deficit ≈13%. IMD classes below 90% of LPA as "deficient". El Niño reached a very strong phase in September.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should drought be declared?"*
→ Where state manuals' triggers are met, yes, promptly; delay denies relief.

P2 *"Export bans: yes or no?"*
→ Only as a last resort and time-bound; predictability matters for farmers and buyers.

P3 *"As Collector, your first three actions?"*
→ Crop-loss assessment by satellite and ground truthing, drinking-water contingency, and MGNREGA work on demand.

Q13 In the India–New Zealand FTA, India kept core dairy out while New Zealand gave 100% duty-free access. Is protecting dairy wise, or is India being protectionist?

MY VIEW: Wise. It shows India can sign ambitious FTAs without sacrificing livelihoods.

Dairy is a livelihood for about 8 crore households, mostly small and landless, and largely women. New Zealand is the world's largest dairy exporter. Opening milk, cheese and butter would expose cooperatives to highly mechanised competition overnight. Dairy was also why India walked away from RCEP.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Protection must be time-bound and used to raise productivity, or it becomes a shelter for inefficiency.
WAY FORWARD	Use the agreement's cooperation on genetics and animal husbandry to raise yields; India liberalised other lines and gained services and mobility access.

MUST-KNOW Signed 27 April 2026; NZ Parliament passed it on 16 September. UPDATE (OCT): in force from 20 October 2026. India has never opened core dairy in any FTA.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Isn't it unfair to demand full access and give less?"*
→ Asymmetry reflects different development levels; New Zealand gains from a large, growing market.

P2 *"Will consumers lose out on cheaper dairy?"*
→ Marginally; but cheaper imports that wipe out 8 crore livelihoods is a poor trade.

P3 *"What should Indian dairy do to compete globally?"*
→ Productivity, disease control, cold chains and branding, the Amul model scaled up.

Q14 The India–US trade deal is still not finalised months after the tariff cut to 18%. What should India's approach be?

MY VIEW: Patient engagement, with red lines on agriculture, dairy and energy autonomy.

The US remains our largest export market, and the February framework cut reciprocal tariffs from 25% to 18%. But the US Supreme Court's February ruling against emergency tariffs changed Washington's legal architecture, and India rightly wants clarity before signing.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Delay has a cost: competitors like Vietnam may lock in better access, and exporters in labour-intensive sectors need certainty now.
WAY FORWARD	Sign an interim tranche on goods where interests align, keep sensitive sectors out, and diversify through FTAs with the UK, EU, EFTA and New Zealand.

MUST-KNOW 2 Feb 2026: US reciprocal tariff on India cut from 25% to 18%. 20 Feb 2026: US Supreme Court struck down IEEPA-based tariffs. Shared goal: $500 billion bilateral trade by 2030.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Is the US a reliable partner?"*
→ On trade, transactional; on technology and defence, deeply aligned. We engage on both tracks.

P2 *"Would you accept GM food imports?"*
→ Not without our own regulatory approval; food safety is a sovereign decision.

P3 *"What is India's leverage?"*
→ Market size, services, a democratic manufacturing alternative to China, and defence purchases.

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SECTION 04

Ecology & Environment

GS-III: Environment & Disaster Management

CONTEXT CAPSULE The southwest monsoon closed on 30 September at 87% of LPA as El Niño strengthened to a very strong phase. The 26 August flash flood from Tibet into Nepal's Rasuwa district, suspected to be a glacial or ice-avalanche outburst, wrecked hydropower projects and left over 100 Indian tourists missing. India's third NDC (2031–35) set a 47% emissions-intensity cut and 60% non-fossil power capacity by 2035.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Geography optional	*"Why are Himalayan floods now happening without rain?"*	Cryosphere change: GLOFs, permafrost thaw, ice-rock avalanches. Cite South Lhonak 2023 and Rasuwa 2026.
Forestry / Botany / Agriculture	*"Is afforestation the right way to meet the carbon-sink target?"*	Native, diverse restoration, not monoculture plantations; community forest rights help.
Home state Uttarakhand / Himachal / Sikkim	*"Should tourism and roads in your state be capped?"*	Carrying-capacity studies and slope-sensitive building codes, not blanket bans.
Public Administration optional	*"Is disaster management too centralised?"*	NDMA sets policy, but districts respond; strengthen DDMAs with funds and staff.

Q15 A strong El Niño gave India its weakest monsoon in a decade. Is Indian agriculture climate-proof?

MY VIEW: Not yet. We have drought-proofed food supply, but not farmer incomes.

With buffer stocks and the PDS, India no longer faces famine in a bad year. But about half our net sown area is still rainfed, and in an El Niño year that farmer absorbs the full loss. IMD's forecast was broadly accurate; the gap is converting forecasts into village-level action.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT India has made real gains: irrigation coverage, drought-tolerant varieties and better forecasting mean losses are far smaller than in 2002 or 2009.

WAY FORWARD "More crop per drop" through micro-irrigation, diversification away from paddy in rainfed zones, watershed restoration, and insurance that pays within weeks.

MUST-KNOW About half of India's net sown area is rainfed. PMKSY's "Per Drop More Crop" for micro-irrigation; PMFBY (2016) for crop insurance.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Why don't farmers switch from paddy?"*
→ Assured MSP and procurement favour paddy; change the incentives and farmers will switch.

P2 *"Is crop insurance working?"*
→ Coverage has grown, but claim delays undermine trust; technology-based yield estimation can fix that.

P3 *"One climate-smart practice you would promote?"*
→ Direct-seeded rice and millets in rainfed areas.

Q16 The Rasuwa flood came without local rain and from across the border. What does it teach India about Himalayan disasters?

MY VIEW: The Himalaya's biggest risks now come from the cryosphere, above the clouds, and they do not respect borders.

1. **New hazard type.** Glacial lake outbursts, ice-rock avalanches and landslide dams strike without rainfall; our warning systems are built for rain.
2. **Infrastructure in harm's way.** Hydropower plants on the Bhotekoshi–Trishuli were damaged, echoing Chamoli 2021 and Teesta-III 2023.
3. **Transboundary data.** Many dangerous lakes lie in Tibet; real-time data sharing with China and Nepal is now a disaster-management need.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Not every disaster is climate-driven; seismic activity, geology and poor construction choices also play a part, and blaming climate can excuse bad planning.

WAY FORWARD End-to-end GLOF early warning for high-risk lakes, community sirens, satellite monitoring, and a hydrological data-sharing protocol with China and Nepal.

MUST-KNOW Rasuwa flash flood: 26 August 2026; 111 MW Rasuwagadhi among damaged projects. Government told Parliament (23 July 2026) no end-to-end GLOF warning system had yet been commissioned in India. NDMA has identified about 189 high-risk glacial lakes.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Will China share data?"*
→ It has shared flood-season data on the Brahmaputra and Sutlej under MoUs before; renewing and widening them is realistic diplomacy.

P2 *"Can warning systems really work in such terrain?"*
→ Sikkim's South Lhonak work shows sensors and sirens can buy crucial minutes.

P3 *"Who should be accountable when a dam fails?"*
→ The developer for design and the regulator for clearance; both need clear liability.

Q17 Should India continue building large hydropower projects in the Himalaya?

MY VIEW: Yes, but fewer, safer and smarter. The question is not whether, but where and how.

Hydropower is firm, clean power that balances solar and wind, and in Arunachal it has strategic value given China's projects upstream on the Yarlung Tsangpo. Abandoning it is not realistic.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Cascading dams on fragile rivers multiply risk, displace communities and damage river ecology; the economic case weakens once disaster risk is priced in.
WAY FORWARD	Cumulative basin-level impact assessment instead of project-by-project clearance, mandatory GLOF risk mapping and sirens upstream of every dam, and preference for run-of-river and small hydro where geology is weak.

MUST-KNOW Chamoli disaster: February 2021 (Rishiganga–Tapovan). Teesta-III (Chungthang) dam breached in the South Lhonak GLOF, October 2023. Cabinet's Small Hydro Power scheme: ₹2,584.60 crore for about 1,500 MW (FY27–31).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Won't this slow development?"*
→ A slower project is cheaper than a destroyed one. Chamoli cost lives and a plant that took years to build.

P2 *"What about local opposition to dams?"*
→ Free, prior consent through Gram Sabhas and fair benefit-sharing reduce conflict.

P3 *"Is the Siang project justified?"*
→ Strategically yes, as a buffer against upstream diversion, but only with full safety and consent.

Q18 Critics say India's 2035 NDC is not ambitious enough and that India keeps expanding coal. Do you agree?

MY VIEW: The NDC is credible and fair. Ambition should be judged by delivery and equity, not headline numbers.

India met its 2030 target of 50% non-fossil capacity about five years early, crossing 52% by early 2026. India has contributed only about 3–4% of historical emissions, and its per-capita emissions are less than half the world average. Coal remains a bridge for baseload while incomes rise.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	A clearer coal-peaking timeline is overdue, and air pollution is a health crisis regardless of climate targets.
WAY FORWARD	Announce a coal-peaking window, scale storage and transmission, and press developed countries to deliver finance; ambition without money is a slogan.

MUST-KNOW NDC 2031–35 (approved 25 March 2026): 47% emissions-intensity cut vs 2005; 60% non-fossil capacity; 3.5–4 bn t CO_2e sink. Non-fossil capacity: 52.57% (February 2026). Net zero target: 2070.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should India commit to a coal phase-out date?"*
→ Not a phase-out date yet; a peaking window is credible and fair.

P2 *"Isn't the carbon-sink target unrealistic?"*
→ It is ambitious; native restoration and agroforestry can deliver if land and community rights are respected.

P3 *"What would you say at COP?"*
→ Equity and finance first: CBDR is not a slogan, it is the basis of the Paris Agreement.

SECTION 05

International Relations

GS-II: International Relations

CONTEXT CAPSULE India hosted the 18th BRICS Summit at Bharat Mandapam on 12–13 September, themed "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability". The 11 members adopted the New Delhi Declaration by consensus. Xi Jinping made his first India visit since 2019; Putin and Iran's President Pezeshkian also came. Earlier, the PM attended the SCO Summit in Bishkek (31 August–1 September). In August, Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
PSIR / History optional	*"Is strategic autonomy just non-alignment renamed?"*	Non-alignment was abstention; strategic autonomy is active multi-engagement from a position of strength.
Hobby: languages / travel	*"You speak Arabic / have lived in the Gulf; what do you make of the Mecca Pact?"*	Gulf states hedge, but their economic stake in India is large and rising.
Home state West Bengal / Northeast	*"How does China's dam affect your region?"*	Water security and flood data; argue for a water-sharing mechanism.
Public Administration optional	*"Can India's diplomatic cadre manage this load?"*	IFS is small for India's ambitions; argue for lateral experts and a larger service.

Q19 India hosted Xi, Putin and the Iranian President in the same week, while negotiating a trade deal with the US. Is this strategic autonomy or fence-sitting?

MY VIEW: Strategic autonomy. Fence-sitting means having no position; India has clear positions and engages everyone to advance them.

India's interests are plural: energy from Russia and the Gulf, markets and technology from the US and Europe, border stability with China, connectivity through Chabahar. Hosting BRICS let India shape the agenda from inside: the Declaration flagged unilateral trade measures and backed dialogue-based dispute resolution.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Multi-alignment has costs. Partners may doubt our reliability in a crisis, and ambiguity can be read as weakness.

WAY FORWARD Consistency on principles such as sovereignty and terrorism, so that our choices are predictable even when partners differ.

MUST-KNOW 18th BRICS Summit: 12–13 September 2026, Bharat Mandapam; theme "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability". New Delhi Declaration adopted by consensus; 20 years of BRICS marked.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Doesn't hosting Iran annoy the US and Israel?"* → They know we engage all sides; we are transparent, and our interests in each are real.
P2	*"Which partner matters most?"* → Different partners for different goals; that is the point of autonomy.
P3	*"What did India gain from BRICS?"* → A consensus text, a reform roadmap and visibility as a convenor in a divided world.

Q20 Xi Jinping visited India for the first time in seven years. Should India trust the thaw with China?

MY VIEW: Engage, but verify. A thaw is welcome; trust must be earned on the ground, at the LAC.

Both leaders committed to a fair and mutually acceptable boundary settlement, building on the 2024 disengagement. Stable ties help: our electronics and pharma industries depend on Chinese inputs. But troops remain deployed, the trade deficit is about $100 billion, and China's closeness to Pakistan was visible in May 2025.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Excessive caution has a cost: we lose investment, components and market access that competitors use to build manufacturing.
WAY FORWARD	De-escalation and de-induction at the border, reduced import dependence through PLI and semiconductors, and calibrated Chinese investment in non-sensitive sectors. Capability, not mood, should drive our China policy.

MUST-KNOW Xi's last India visit: Mamallapuram informal summit, 2019. October 2024: patrolling arrangement for Depsang and Demchok. Bilateral trade deficit with China: about $99–100 billion.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Should India allow Chinese FDI again?"* → Selectively: in non-sensitive manufacturing with local partners and data safeguards.
P2	*"What about the Yarlung Tsangpo dam?"* → Raise it bilaterally, demand data sharing, and build our own storage on the Siang.
P3	*"Can India and China cooperate globally?"* → Yes, on climate finance and WTO reform, even while competing elsewhere.

Q21 Is BRICS becoming an anti-Western bloc, and does that suit India?

MY VIEW: It risks being seen that way; India's role is to keep it non-Western, not anti-Western.

Expansion to 11 members brought in countries that want it as a counterweight to the US. India supports reform of the IMF, World Bank and UN Security Council and local-currency trade, but not a BRICS currency or de-dollarisation as a political project.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	With China's economic weight, BRICS may drift towards Beijing's agenda regardless of India's efforts, and expansion dilutes coherence.
WAY FORWARD	Use consensus rules to block what harms us, push the New Development Bank towards infrastructure and climate, and keep BRICS complementary to the Quad and G20.

MUST-KNOW First BRIC foreign ministers' meeting 2006; first summit Yekaterinburg 2009. New Development Bank: agreed 2014 (Fortaleza), HQ Shanghai.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should India leave BRICS if it becomes anti-US?"*
→ No; leaving cedes the table to China. Influence comes from inside.

P2 *"Is de-dollarisation in India's interest?"*
→ Rupee trade settlement, yes; replacing the dollar with a Chinese-led system, no.

P3 *"Quad and BRICS at once: contradiction?"*
→ No; they serve different purposes. India is a bridge, not a camp follower.

Q22 What does the Mecca Pact between Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan mean for India?

MY VIEW: A concern to monitor, not a crisis. It reflects Gulf states hedging after the Iran war, not a turn against India.

The pact treats an attack on one as an attack on all, linking nuclear-armed Pakistan with Turkey's defence industry and Saudi money. In a future India–Pakistan crisis, it could complicate Gulf neutrality. But India's Gulf ties are deep: about 90 lakh Indians in the region, large remittances, energy trade and investment partnerships.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT It does strengthen Pakistan's diplomatic and financial position, and Turkey's role adds a hostile voice on Kashmir.

WAY FORWARD Deepen defence and security cooperation with the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Egypt, accelerate IMEC, and keep channels open with Turkey. Be too valuable a partner to antagonise.

MUST-KNOW Mecca Joint Defence Agreement signed 7 August 2026. Builds on the Saudi–Pakistan Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement (September 2025).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Would Saudi Arabia fight India for Pakistan?"*
→ Very unlikely; Saudi economic interest in India is far greater. The pact is aimed at regional threats.

P2 *"Is this an "Islamic NATO"?"*
→ Not yet; it lacks integrated command and shared threat perception.

P3 *"How should India respond publicly?"*
→ Calmly; avoid over-reaction and focus on bilateral strengths.

Q23 The US–Iran war has dragged on since February. What should India's stance be?

MY VIEW: Call for de-escalation and freedom of navigation, protect our citizens and energy, and avoid taking sides in a war that is not ours.

India has relations with Israel, Iran, the Gulf states and the US, and each matters. Our priorities are concrete: diaspora safety, crude and LPG supplies, Chabahar, and shipping through Hormuz and the Red Sea, where the Indian Navy has a role.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Neutrality can look like indifference to civilian suffering and can limit our influence with all sides.

WAY FORWARD Keep channels open with all parties, as hosting President Pezeshkian at BRICS showed, and offer humanitarian help and a possible bridging role.

MUST-KNOW War began with US–Israel strikes on Iran on 28 February 2026. Hormuz carries about one-fifth of global oil. India signed a 10-year Chabahar terminal contract in May 2024.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should India condemn any side?"*
→ We condemn attacks on civilians and violations of international law, consistently, without picking camps.

P2 *"Can India mediate?"*
→ As a facilitator of messages, yes; formal mediation needs both sides' request.

P3 *"What about Indians in the Gulf?"*
→ Evacuation plans, embassy helplines, and the Navy's readiness, as in past operations.

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SECTION 06

Science & Technology

GS-III: Science & Technology

CONTEXT CAPSULE At SEMICON India (17–19 September, New Delhi; 600+ companies from 52 countries), the PM unveiled the $13.5 billion second phase of the India Semiconductor Mission and marked commercial production at two plants. ISRO launched GSLV-F17/EOS-05 on 4 September and reaffirmed the first uncrewed Gaganyaan flight within 2026. Deepfake rules under the IT Amendment Rules, 2026 are in force, and broader AI guardrails are under consultation.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Electronics / Computer Science graduate	*"What is the difference between a fab and an OSAT unit?"*	Fab makes the wafer; OSAT assembles, tests and packages. India is strong in design and starting OSAT.
Physics / Space interest	*"Why is a human-rated rocket different?"*	Higher reliability margins, crew escape system and life support.
Law graduate	*"Do the deepfake rules violate Article 19?"*	Labelling is proportionate; vague takedown powers need safeguards (Shreya Singhal).
Public Administration optional	*"Can AI improve governance?"*	Yes, for grievance redress and targeting, with human oversight and audit.

Q24 India imports about 90% of its chips. With Semicon 2.0, is India's semiconductor ambition realistic or an expensive subsidy race?

MY VIEW: Realistic if we play to our strengths: packaging, design and mature nodes first, cutting-edge fabs later.

Chips are now strategic, like oil. The Hormuz crisis showed the cost of single-source dependence, and Taiwan carries a similar risk for chips. India has a large share of the world's chip-design engineers, and assembly-testing units are entering commercial production.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Fabs need assured power, ultra-pure water, a supplier ecosystem and decades of patience, and subsidies can be captured by a few firms. Competing with TSMC at 3 nm now is not sensible.

WAY FORWARD Milestone-linked subsidies, university fab-labs for talent, and assured demand through automobiles, defence and electronics. Measure success by the ecosystem, not ribbon-cutting.

MUST-KNOW India Semiconductor Mission (2021), ₹76,000 crore; Semicon 2.0: $13.5 billion. SEMICON India 2026: 17–19 September, 600+ companies, 52 countries. India imports about 90% of its chips (≈$30 billion a year).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Why not just import from trusted partners?"*
→ Trust can change in a crisis; some domestic capacity is insurance.

P2 *"Is the subsidy too high?"*
→ High, but comparable to the US CHIPS Act and others; the real risk is poor execution.

P3 *"Which state is best placed?"*
→ Gujarat and Assam have early units; what matters is water, power and talent clusters.

Q25 Deepfakes are being used in scams and elections. Should India regulate AI through a dedicated law?

MY VIEW: Regulate harms, not the technology. A light framework law with sector-specific rules beats a sweeping AI Act.

One survey cited by analysts found 47% of Indian adults had faced, or knew someone hit by, an AI voice-clone or deepfake scam. The 2026 IT Rules rightly require labelling of synthetic content and fast takedowns.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Vague rules and very short takedown windows can chill legitimate speech and satire, and burden Indian startups more than global giants.

WAY FORWARD Liability for proven misuse, mandatory provenance for political ads, strong deepfake detection under the IndiaAI Mission, and an independent grievance appeal to protect Article 19.

MUST-KNOW IT (Intermediary Guidelines) Amendment Rules, 2026: notified 10 February, effective 20 February; synthetic content must be labelled. India AI Governance Guidelines (November 2025): risk-based approach. Shreya Singhal v. UoI (2015) struck down Sec. 66A for vagueness.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should AI-generated election content be banned?"*
→ Not banned; labelled, with provenance, and with penalties for deceptive deepfakes of candidates.

P2	*"Who is liable, the creator or the platform?"* → The creator primarily; platforms lose safe harbour if they ignore labelling or takedown duties.
P3	*"Is the EU model better?"* → It is comprehensive but heavy; India needs agility and lower compliance costs for startups.

Q26 Gaganyaan has been delayed repeatedly. Should a developing country spend on human spaceflight?

MY VIEW: Yes. Delays reflect safety, not failure, and the returns go well beyond prestige.

Human spaceflight builds capabilities in life support, materials, medicine and reliable rockets that spill into civilian industry. It underpins the Bharatiya Antariksh Station and a crewed lunar mission by 2040. Rushing a crewed launch to meet a date would be far costlier than a delay.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Opportunity cost is real: the same money could fund health or education, and repeated delays can erode public confidence.

WAY FORWARD Keep ISRO's budget focused on frontier missions, open launches and satellites to private players, and communicate timelines honestly.

MUST-KNOW GSLV-F17/EOS-05 launched 4 September 2026 from the Second Launch Pad. Targets: Bharatiya Antariksh Station by 2035; Indian on the Moon by 2040. IN-SPACe (2020) authorises private space activity.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Should private players take over?"* → Increasingly, for launches and satellites. ISRO should move up the value chain to science and human spaceflight.
P2	*"Is space a strategic domain?"* → Yes: navigation, surveillance and communication are critical; NavIC reduces GPS dependence.
P3	*"What is your view on space debris?"* → India should support binding norms and build its own tracking capacity.

SECTION 07

Rapid-fire Board Traps

One or two sentences, then stop

Trap question	Safe, honest line
"Do you support the Gen Z protesters?"	I support their right to protest and their demand for clean exams; I would not support violence or blocking essential services.
"Is the Election Commission compromised?"	I have no evidence of that; I believe institutional design should leave no room for doubt.
"Is caste census divisive?"	Data does not divide; how it is used can. I support counting, with safeguards on use.
"Should India stop buying Russian oil to please the US?"	Energy decisions should follow national interest and price; we can address partners' concerns without surrendering autonomy.

Trap question	Safe, honest line
"Was hosting Xi a mistake after Galwan?"	No; talking does not mean trusting. The border situation decides the pace of normalisation.
"Is 7.8% growth real when people feel prices rising?"	Both are true: output is growing, but inflation erodes purchasing power. Policy must address both.
"Is Naxalism finished?"	The armed movement nearly is; grievances are not. Governance must fill the space.
"Should all Himalayan hydro projects stop?"	No; stop the unsafe ones, and assess basins cumulatively.
"Is India's NDC weak?"	It is credible and has over-delivered before; fairness also matters.
"Do we need an AI law?"	We need rules against harm, not rules against innovation.

Three Closing Tips

- If asked "What would you do as DM / SP / Collector?", always cover prevention, response and accountability.
- If a board member strongly disagrees, acknowledge the point and restate yours once; do not repeat it a third time.
- Never criticise a named individual or party. Critique policies and institutions, with a solution.

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SECTION 08

Practice Lab

Ten unanswered questions • Self-evaluation rubric

How to practise: answer each question aloud in 90 seconds, recording yourself. Then ask a friend to play the board and press you with two follow-ups. Score yourself on the rubric below; anything under 11 out of 15 needs another attempt.

#	Question	Score /15
1.	Should exam-paper leaks be made a non-bailable offence with a special court in every state?	
2.	Is the Special Intensive Revision a model the Election Commission should repeat every ten years?	
3.	Should the 50% ceiling on reservation be revisited after caste data is released?	
4.	If you were the Finance Secretary, would you cut excise duty on petrol and diesel today?	
5.	Does India need a National Energy Security Act?	
6.	Should the Himalayan states have a separate carrying-capacity-based development model?	
7.	Is the Mecca Pact a reason for India to deepen ties with Israel and Greece?	
8.	Should India join a BRICS payment system?	
9.	Should government data be used to train Indian AI models? What safeguards would you set?	
10.	Your district has a GLOF-prone lake upstream. Draw up your first-week action plan.	

Self-Evaluation Rubric

Criterion	1 – Needs work	2 – Adequate	3 – Board-ready
Clarity of view	Position unclear or buried	Position stated but hedged	Clear view in first sentence
Reasoning & facts	No fact or wrong fact	One relevant fact	Two reasons + one precise fact
Balance	One-sided	Mentions other side vaguely	Concedes strongest counterpoint honestly
Way forward	None	Generic ("awareness, coordination")	Specific, administrative, feasible
Composure under follow-up	Defensive or changes stand	Holds stand but repeats	Accepts valid point, holds core calmly